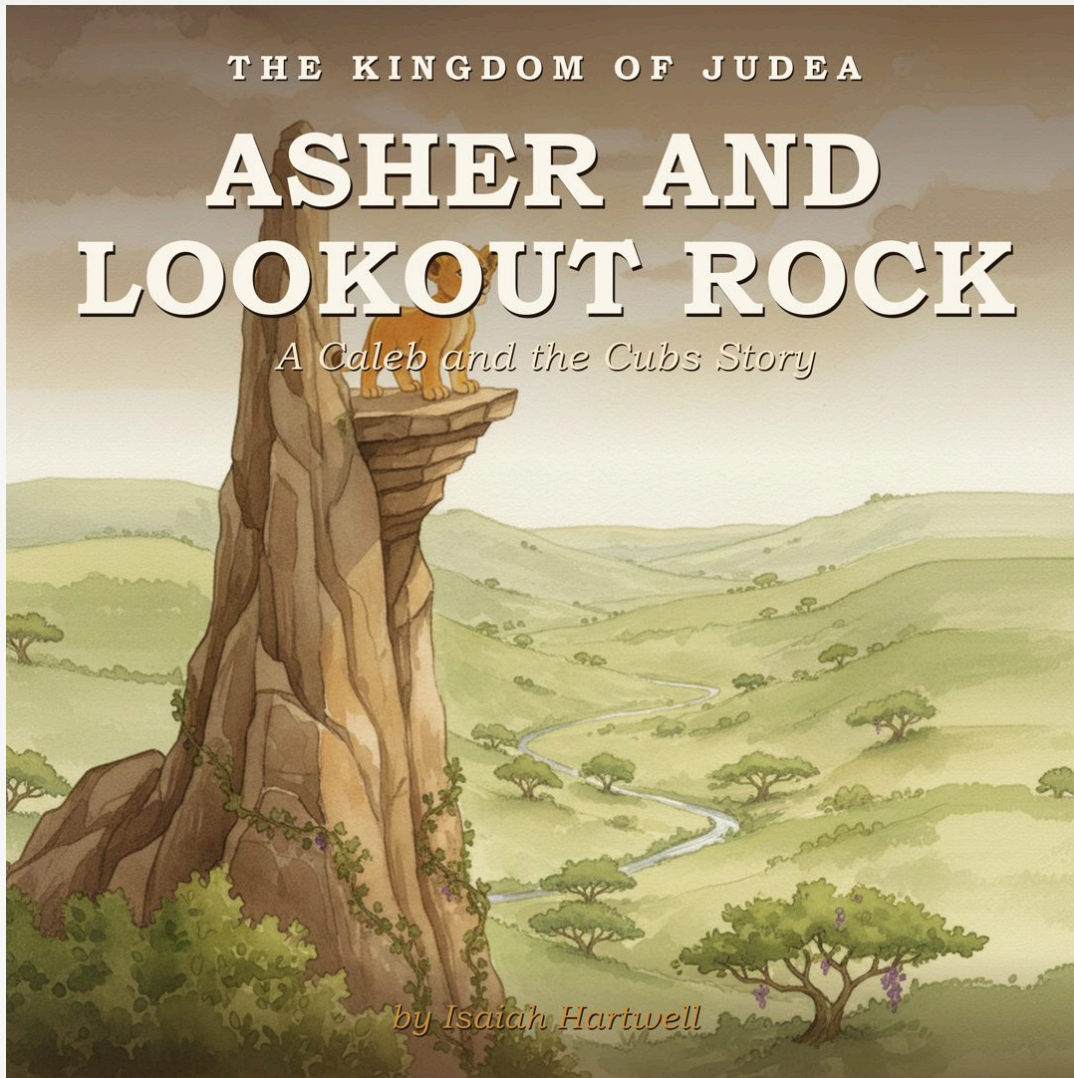




THE KINGDOM OF JUDEA

## Asher and Lookout Rock

# **Asher and Lookout Rock**

# Asher and Lookout Rock

The Kingdom of Judea · Book Three

Made Out of Clay Productions

*God's Love Never Fails*

by Isaiah Hartwell

*For our son, Clayton*



the den was almost a den.

Mama had unpacked her corner at last.

Papa could lift his paw a little higher than yesterday —  
but only a little.

Ezra sat apart with his thoughts,  
the way he had sat

since the family crossed into Judea.

Tirzah had laughed once — a real laugh.

Leah had not.

And the family had not had a long, good drink  
in two days.

The little stream beside the den  
had gone thin, then muddy,  
then thinner still.

Before they could truly stay,  
the family needed water —  
real, moving water.





and looked east, to Lookout Rock —  
the one tall stone at the edge of the valley,  
where a climb halfway up  
could show a lion the whole land below —  
and whether there was water in it.  
He tried his shoulder.  
It would not lift today  
the way a father's shoulder  
is supposed to lift.  
I would go, he thought.  
Today, I cannot go.  
His eye went first to Ezra —  
oldest, fastest, nearly grown —  
sitting apart, with his back to the morning.  
Caleb looked at his eldest son  
the way fathers look at sons  
they cannot send today.  
Then his eye moved on,  
and found Asher.





Papa's voice was quiet,  
the way it went quiet when something mattered.

"Do you see Lookout Rock, to the east?

Halfway up, there is a ledge.

From the ledge, you can see  
if there is water below.

Go. Find out. Come back fast.

The family needs the answer  
before the sun stands high.

And son — do not go over the top."

Papa did not say I would have sent Ezra.

Papa did not need to.

He laid his good paw, once, warm,  
on his second son's head.

Asher stood as tall  
as he had ever stood.



like a cub who had just been handed  
a task the size of a father.

He did not run.  
But he did not stop, either.

Mama watched him go,  
smaller and smaller  
at the edge of the wide open land.

Small paws, she thought.  
Brave heart.

She did not call him back.

That is one of the bravest things  
a mother ever does.





The path was hot.  
The sun climbed faster than he wanted it to,  
like it was racing him.

"What's the worst that could happen?"  
Asher said to himself —

half grin,  
half gulp.

The wind didn't answer.

So he climbed the way Mama had taught him to walk —  
one paw at a time.  
Then the next one.  
Then the one after that.

The land just kept opening up below him,  
bigger,  
and bigger,  
and bigger.



The top was right there —  
just a little higher.  
Part of him wanted it,  
the way you want the very top of things.  
But Papa had said do not go over the top.  
So Asher stopped where he was told,  
right there on the ledge.  
And there —  
far below,  
threading silver through the rocks —  
water.  
Real water.  
Moving water.  
Enough-for-everyone water.  
Asher's chest felt bigger than the rest of him.  
He had the answer.  
He had the very answer Papa needed.







fast and proud,  
the song running in his head  
the way songs do  
when nobody invites them:

God is near.  
God is here —

His paws barely touched the rock.

Almost home.

Almost a hero.



Leah.

Sitting alone on a flat stone.

Her red flower had slipped down beside her ear,  
and she had not fixed it.

Her face was wet.

Asher stopped as if the path had ended.

Never — not once, not ever in his whole life —  
had Asher seen Leah cry.







The mission pulled at him, hard.  
Get back. Tell Papa. The family is thirsty.

He thought of Tirzah's small dry tongue.  
He thought of Papa watching the rocks for him.  
He thought of come back fast.

And a small voice inside him said:  
she'll be embarrassed.  
she doesn't want to be seen.  
keep going.

But his heart —

his heart said one word.

Stay.



He did not say stand tall.

He did not say don't cry.

He did not say Papa is waiting.

He did not say anything at all.

He just stayed.







Leah said one small thing,  
in a voice he had never heard her use.

"I keep telling myself I'm not afraid.

I was the brave one back there.  
I don't know how to be the brave one here."

Asher did not have words big enough for that.  
No lion does.

So he leaned his shoulder against hers,  
the way he had leaned against Tirzah  
the whole long walk to Judea.

And he stayed some more.



Leah breathed all the way out.

She did not say thank you.  
Thank you is not a thing Leah says.

But she stood up.  
And she fixed her flower.

And they walked home together, side by side,  
the whole way down —  
saying nothing,  
saying everything.

The sun was lower than it should have been.





when they came over the last rise.

He stood up too fast for his shoulder,  
and winced.

Behind him, Tirzah lifted her head, slow and dry.

And the wonderful water-answer Asher carried  
suddenly felt small.

I made Papa worry.

I took too long.

I failed Tirzah.

I failed.



and gave his report like a grown lion.

"Papa. There is water.  
A thin silver line in the rocks.  
You can see it from the ledge."

Then his voice went small.

"And — I'm sorry I took so long.  
Leah needed me. I stayed.

I knew everyone was waiting.  
I knew you said come back fast.

I stayed anyway."

And Asher stood there, waiting  
to be told what he should have done instead.





Papa stepped close  
and laid his good paw across Asher's back,  
and Mama came up warm on the other side.  
"Son," Papa said — quiet, true —  
"water is important. Water is real.  
We needed that answer, and you brought it.  
But your sister is worth more than water.  
Your sister is worth more than my worry,  
or the high sun,  
or how fast you came home.  
The lion who stops on the path  
to sit with his sister while she is breaking —  
that lion is doing  
the strongest thing a lion can do.  
Claws down. Hearts up.  
You lived it today, son,  
before anyone taught you the words.  
God does not look at the outside.  
God looks at the heart.  
And He saw yours today,  
on that path."



That night, the family curled close together  
in the den that was finally beginning  
to feel like a den.

Leah leaned against Asher  
without saying so.

Across the den, Papa went  
and sat down next to Ezra.

He did not say anything.

Ezra did not move away.

It was a start.

And Asher closed his eyes and thought:

Maybe being the heart  
was never the smaller calling.

Maybe being the heart  
was the calling  
all along.

Love is stronger than the roar.

Soft as breath, he said the song —

their song,

the song that had walked all this way with them:

God is near.

God is here.

God's love never fails.

He hears every word.

And He sees the heart  
behind it.

---